

LOCKED IN

A one-act, one-actor script. Single location: a kitchen studio.

SETTING: A kitchen studio — the kind rigged for filming. Overhead lights, a mounted camera facing a clean counter, a ring light off to one side. MARCUS (30s) enters holding a phone, unaware or half-aware the space looks like a set. Morning.

MARCUS

(surveying the room)

Who books a *kitchen studio* for a video interview? "Somewhere quiet with good light," they said. This place has better lighting than I've had in any relationship.

(He steps toward the counter, catches his reflection in the dark camera lens.)

Great. Now I'm on camera before I'm even on camera.

(He sets the phone down, paces the small space.)

Okay. It's an interview. People do these every day. They liked the résumé — that's why they called. You don't drag somebody into a room with three-point lighting because you *hate* their résumé.

(He stops at the ring light, tilts it, watches the glow shift across his face.)

Seven months out of work. Seven. My last boss said, "You have real potential, Marcus." Then laid me off forty minutes later. So forgive me if a room this polished makes me nervous. Polished rooms have delivered bad news before.

(He leans on the counter, talks to the audience.)

"So, Marcus, tell me about yourself." *(beat)* Which self? The one on the résumé — or the one who ate cereal at this exact counter three nights running because standing in a kitchen felt like almost cooking?

(He straightens. Something shifts.)

Truth is I'm not scared of the job. I'm scared of wanting it. Want it and lose it, that's another crack — and I'm running low on places to crack.

(The phone buzzes. He freezes. Looks.)

Two minutes early. Of course.

(A long breath. He steps into the light in front of the camera. His posture opens.)

You know what? No. Done apologizing for being in the room. Seven months didn't break me. It just taught me what I'll put up with and what I won't.

(He taps to answer, warm and alive now.)

"Hi — Marcus. Thanks so much for making the time. No, I'm ready. Let's do it."

(A real smile. The studio lights hold on him.)

BLACKOUT.

END.